

Tom Clancy's HAWX

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Tom Clancy's *HAWX*, an abbreviation of High-Altitude Warfare eXperimental is one of the strangest flight simulators we've seen. It appears to be a flight simulator, but is more properly a futuristic arcade air combat game. Once you're in the cockpit, you can fly and turn the plane the way you want, and almost never stall. You have a virtually unlimited supply of fuel and ammunition. This makes the game very enjoyable for about the first five minutes or so. It's fun to blow

up tanks flying upside down and very close to the ground, which is something you could never do in the classic air combat simulators such as the F-22 Raptor.

The first few levels are very enjoyable. New enemies keep showing up, and a variety of systems on your part help. Unfortunately, it is all too unrealistic, you launch missiles in what looks like a dogfight, instead of when the enemy planes are blips at the edge of your radar. The enemies are numerous, but too passive; getting locked on hardly ever happens, and even if you run out of flares, you can evade them easily. Even if the missiles

do hit you, they don't do any critical damage. The game uses a number of in-game guiding systems, to help you navigate. One of them shows up trails of yellow frames that you have to follow to successfully complete the mission. For example, approaching a protected anti-aircraft gun at a right angle to destroy it, or to avoid detection by a radar. Another mode, which gives you an external mode, is more of a trial-and-error sort of game play, where controlling the plane becomes ridiculously difficult from being ridiculously simple.

The worst part about the game is the terrain. Although the game claims to be high-altitude warfare, you stay pretty close to the terrain most of the time, as a lot of levels involve taking out or protecting ground units. All the buildings and the features in the terrain are smaller than what they would be if they were scaled proportionally to the plane. If you are flying low over the buildings, it is easy to mistake the city to be lower down, as they appear so tiny on screen. Then you crash into a building that is half the size of your plane, and you have to load from the last checkpoint.

The game has a strangely gripping storyline. Initially, you work for the US Army, and are then hired by a private security firm by the name of Artemis. In fact, Artemis hires out your entire squadron. Now, Artemis contracts out missions to

Publisher: Ubisoft
Developer: Ubisoft Romania
Platform: PC

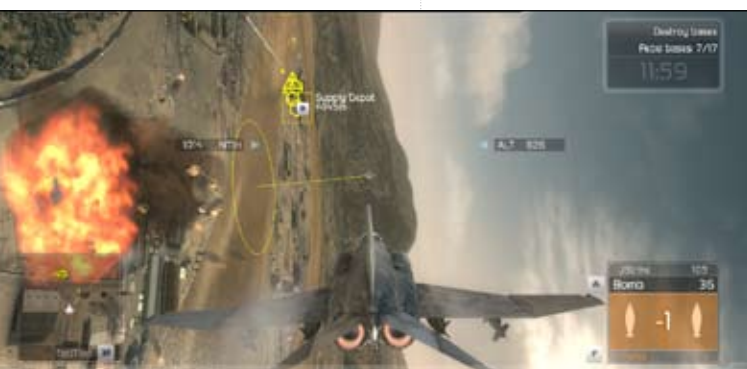
Score: 4/10



Lock on four targets at once



Fly upside down without stalling



Deploy bombs while flying sideways



different private organisations and governments. The tongue-in-cheek remarks about the US Army is fun, but one of the missions makes you attack the US Army itself. The game will appeal to you if you are a patriot in the US. Not a good time to have such a storyline.

The problem with the game is this – the missions are too long for casual playing. Serious players won't like the arcade style of the flight simulation, and the action is too slow, for those who like FPS games. The game is neither real enough nor unreal enough, and a compromise between the two simply doesn't make sense. **D**